

IT IS A BITTER-SWEET MEMORY, I NEARLY WON THE BRONZE

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P. T. Usha

I have several fond memories from the four Olympics that I competed in and a few others that I have been to over the last four decades as a coach and then as an observer.

And now I am going to attend another Olympics as the president of the Indian Olympic Association. I am very much looking forward to Paris.

People still talk about my 400m hurdles final in Los Angeles in 1984. For me it is a bitter-sweet memory. I nearly won the bronze; I missed it by one hundredth of a second.

Yes, it was a great moment for Indian athletics, especially at a time when an Olympic medal seemed a distant dream. But I was devastated that I couldn't get a medal despite coming so close.

I was confident of my medal

chances, despite the fact that I had boarded the flight to the United States after running in just two 400m hurdles races. **I had done well in the heats and then the semifinals. India was expecting a lot from me, especially after the disappointment in hockey: we had failed to qualify for the semifinals.**

There was a lot of media focus on

me, but that didn't matter. When I run, I forget everything else.

I was also part of the 4x400m relay team, along with Shiny Wilson, M. D. Valsamma and Vandana Rao. We reached the final and came up with a fine show, too. I believe that was our finest ever relay team.

Right from my first Olympics in Moscow, when I was just 16, I have



I began my Olympic journey in Moscow as a teenager whose only aim was not to finish last in her races, and I didn't. I consider myself fortunate that I could be part of so many Olympics.